

What Were the Silk Roads?

Class 1 lecture • The Silk Roads as connected networks of trade, travel, and exchange

A Network, Not One Road

The Silk Roads connected cities, oases, ports, empires, and local markets.

Merchants usually moved goods in stages rather than traveling the full route.

Overland and maritime routes linked East Asia, Central Asia, South Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Europe.

What Moved Along the Routes?

Goods: silk, spices, horses, ceramics, glassware, paper, and precious metals.

Ideas: Buddhism, Islam, artistic styles, scientific knowledge, and technologies.

People: merchants, pilgrims, diplomats, soldiers, translators, and migrants.